

Depravity



A boat, high and dry, hull tired, grass in the seams. It is not a little off course. It is not sailing.

Before you gather

- Read Day 6, Depravity, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Ezekiel 37:1–6, 9–10 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

Have you ever pushed a car with a dead battery? What finally had to happen?

Leader. Someone else had to bring power. Do not say the point for them yet. Then open Ezekiel 37. The bones cannot help themselves. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: That boat is not a little off course. It is dead in the sand. Apart from God's grace, so are we.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Depravity refers to the deep corruption of human nature due to sin, resulting in our inability to please God, understand spiritual truth rightly, or come to Him apart from His grace.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek nekros — dead, lifeless, without power. The day's text calls us dead, not merely damaged.

MEMORY VERSE · EPHESIANS 2:1–2

And you were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked, following the course of this world, following the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that is now at work in the sons of disobedience.

Together, open the flashcard for Depravity. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Ezekiel 37:1–6, 9–10

Ezekiel stands in a valley of very dry bones. God asks if they can live. Stay in the story. Ask what the bones can do. The answer is nothing. God speaks, and breath comes. Do not reteach the journal.

The hand of the LORD was upon me, and he brought me out in the Spirit of the LORD and set me down in the middle of the valley; it was full of bones... and behold, they were very dry. And he said to me, "Son of man, can these bones live?" And I answered, "O Lord GOD, you know." Then he said to me, "Prophecy over these bones... Behold, I will cause breath to enter you, and you shall live." So I prophesied as he commanded me, and the breath came into them, and they lived and stood on their feet, an exceedingly great army.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What can the bones do for themselves in this story, and who acts? CORE

Leader. They are very dry. They do not decide, cooperate, or improve. God says He will cause breath to enter them. Ezekiel prophesies as he is commanded. They live and stand. Life is God's act.

2. God asks, 'Can these bones live?' Ezekiel answers, 'O Lord GOD, you know.' Why is that better than optimism?

Leader. Hope is in God's power, not in the bones' potential. Depravity ends our confidence in human ability. It does not end our confidence in God. He is able to make the dead live.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 2:1 says you were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked. What is the difference between needing a little help and needing to be made alive?

Leader. Help assumes a living patient. Death requires resurrection. Apart from grace we cannot please God, understand the truth rightly, or come to Him. Evangelism is not advice. It is the Word, and prayer that God gives life.

4. Romans 8:7-8 says the mind set on the flesh cannot submit to God's law. Why does that offend us, and why is it good news if it is true? **CORE**

Leader. It offends pride. It is good news because the answer is not 'try harder.' God makes the dead alive in Christ. Jesus came to die and rise for the helpless. This was never a backup plan.

5. John 6:44 says no one can come to Jesus unless the Father draws him. How should that change the way we pray for people who do not care about God?

Leader. Prayer is not a backup plan. If they are dead, asking the Father to draw them is the work, right beside telling them the gospel. We speak. God gives life. Results are His.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Apart from Jesus we are not weak. We are dead, and only God can make us alive.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • THIS WEEK • 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Help someone far from Jesus before they clean up their life. Tell them we do not need better advice. We need God to make the dead alive, and that is what He does through Jesus.

Leader. Do not run a savior project. Be a neighbor and speak the truth. A kindness that never says they need new life in Christ is not the whole challenge. You cannot raise the dead. God can. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Father, thank You for any spiritual breath in this room. It did not come from us.
2. We pray by name for people who seem dry. Draw them. Make them alive through Jesus.
3. Humble us. This diagnosis is about us before it is about them.

Before you stumble

Total depravity does not mean everyone is as bad as they could be. People still love their children and tell some truth. It means every part is touched by the fall, and we cannot save ourselves or want the true God on our own. Say that plainly if the phrase scares someone. This is a spiritual diagnosis, not a comment on their worth or their sadness. The image of God from week 1 still stands. Do not turn deadness into a feelings exercise.

WITH STUDENTS

Use the dead battery, not a lecture. Ask, 'What is something you cannot make yourself want?' Then connect that to loving God. Read Ephesians 2:1. Dead is God's word, not an insult.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 11:38-44. Lazarus comes out because Jesus calls. Same point, shorter if Ezekiel ran long. The dead man does not assist the miracle.